up their demands by periodically bringing production to a halt, arrests of their leaders notwithstanding, and the government continues to express concern about profits lost by their 'development partner', Vale.

Vale: 'worst company in the world'

In January 2012, Vale had the dubious honour of being voted the 'worst company in the world'. The awards ceremony took place during the World Economic Forum in Davos, Switzerland, which has become in recent years a popular, extra-parliamentary gathering place for powerful business and government leaders to deliberate about corporate-led globalisation. Two Swiss-based organisations, Greenpeace and the Berne Declaration, have used the World Economic Forum to focus on the negative social and environmental practices of global corporate players. For the past eight years, they have given a Public Eye award based on an online competition for the 'worst company in the world'. Vale was awarded the 2012 'Nobel prize of shame', winning 25 000 of the 88 000 votes cast.

The award was presented by Joseph Stiglitz, winner of a genuine Nobel Prize in economics for earlier work he had done problematising the efficacy of market mechanisms. Stiglitz is former head of the World Bank, and now a prestigious dissenting voice in global forums, where he often utters dire warnings about where unregulated globalisation is taking us. In his presentation, Stiglitz mused aloud about how long powerful global players like Vale and Rio Tinto and BHP Billiton could operate with so little regard for the social and environmental consequences of their projects and so little accountability to the '99%' of the population who are excluded from their game plans. Stiglitz went on to say that to protect our planet and our society, we depend not only on government regulations to prevent abuses, but also on a broadening of our concept of self-interest, both for individuals and corporations.

It is in everyone's interest – even the richest 1% – that our planet thrive, that the divide between the haves and the have-nots not be too excessive. For firms, this entails corporate responsibility, going beyond the minimum required by the law to protect the environment. It means treating workers with decency and fairness, not exploiting all the advantages that asymmetries in bargaining might afford (Stiglitz 2012).

Vale and global security

Vale's aggressive expansion in the years since its privatisation has made it the second-largest mining company in the world with operations in 16 Brazilian states and in 33 countries on six continents. Despite its origins as a state company